

Word Count: 1155

*As I Live*

*Content warning: LGBTQ murder*

I'm not dead yet, and the drive is beautiful. We're on a bright country road. A horse trail really. As children, my Mother told us four to be safe back here! Our county's roads are ancient Powhatan paths, which themselves were once simple deer trails. Now, there are large gravel rocks where pavement might be in a decade or two. I slam into the side of the truck bed. My head pops out from under a pile of wood.

I see great dust clouds kick up behind Randy's tires in his rearview mirror. We drift around another turn, and I slide again. In the momentum, I feel a two by four on my side. It stings and is warm.

They had thrown the wood over me before driving. The constant sliding allows me to use its momentum to push up. I can see out the sides, but can't move my legs or hands.

To the right, there's an irrigation ditch. Farmers and critters make use of it alike. Albeit, for very different reasons.

There are horses, cows, and even goats munching on hay along the way. Their earthly scent assaults me. I can't help but think "me too" on seeing the cow's yellow ear tags.

The boys never took their knife out. Even after binding my hands, and legs they stared in fright. Randy mentioned wanting to have more fun, but I think he was the only one who didn't help.

Each turn pulls the knife out a bit further. Until the bolster fully catches and it slides right out. The bleeding quickens. I feel the pulse in my finger tips vibrate. Great pools collect in the truck bed. It runs along the wood, and drips out the gate. How much darker it seems than anything the sun touches.

I'm able to wiggle my bound hands up to my head. They're drenched in blood. I try writing their names to stay conscious. It doesn't work.

Randy is driving harshly, Ted is sliding right on his phone, and Chris twitches riding bitch. I think he feels me slipping, because for no reason he stops shouting and turns to stare at me. His face is pure horror when he sees their names as half finished bloody sigils.

My last breath is a laugh. Fucking Chris out of all people is captivated. My departure is pulling all hope from his eyes. Creating a moment of clarity which Chris can't contain. He freezes. He was always the first to panic.

We round a corner drifting at high speed. It's the forty-five degree compound turn a mile before their house. As we curve, the wind sways the trees. I'm pulled by centripetal force right out of my body. Making it a smooth and natural movement.

To be precise, I die and leave my body before it hits the other side of the truck.

"This is fucked." Chris turns Ted's head.

"What did you think was gonna happen?" Ted laughs. He goes back to looking at his phone.

"Fuck, did it die?" Randy asks.

"Looks that way." Ted laughs.

Randy squeezes the steering wheel at ten and three. His knuckles are white.

"And who's gonna help me clean my truck?" Randy barks.

“Relax brother. Just dump it here.” Ted points to the ditch.

Carl is still staring at the body. His hand shakes as he tries to light a Camel Crush.

Randy slams on the breaks. They stop dead center in the road.

With little effort, the three toss the wood and it in the irrigation ditch. Randy is quick to help this time. The only ceremony comes from circling vultures, and they caw with delight. Otherwise, the boys are quiet.

The boys brush leaves and top soil over my bare skin. Only the insects check to see if I’m alright. To their glee, I am not.

“Make sure her feet are covered.” Randy throws a clump of litter and leaves.

“What, she always had big ass feet.” Randy says.

There’s an attempt at a laugh by Ted. They hop back in, and drive off. They leave the body there. No final insults. Just a frenzy now dead in a ditch.

I hover above and feel no pain. Strange how much kinder our eyes are from the outside. I do weep. My tears hit the feet. The final one breaks the dirt so a big toe sticks out. The moment I feel peace, I flash and appear in their front yard.

It’s a patchwork of dried pine needles, red ants, and islands of green. There’s a red sign by the drive in the front. It looks normal for the area, save for the fact Chris is pacing in the upstairs window. Still shaking, and still smoking.

As I float up, I see the truck bed has been cleaned. Pools of red wine bubbles linger around the garage drain. There’s several drops marking the truck’s path. In the night, it’s too akin to darkness to sift out.

I stare at the three men inside. Randy is yelling at the TV. As Chris passes him, Randy grabs and throws him on the couch.

“Damn Randy,” Chris cries.

Randy slaps him and flicks open his pocket knife pointing at Chris' mouth. He slowly turns the knife as he pushes through the air.

“Jesus Randy.” Chris yelps. “It's soaked.”

“Ah fuck, come on Randy.” Ted starts to laugh. “You can't kill all our friends in one night.”

Randy stops. He puts the blade in his back pocket, and reaches for a beer.

“That bitch scratched up your face dummy. You're still bleeding.” Randy says.

Ted feels the four lines I dragged across his face. Pieces of my white nail polish are still stuck in the cuts. He laughs as his fingertips soak.

“Damn, I didn't even notice.” Ted laughs.

I know I can't stay for too much longer. I feel that where my knees used to be. Something is sweetly saying to move along. So, I give in to this force, blink, and it becomes morning. This time, I'm in the cab with the boys.

The three are showered, shaved, and slumped in the truck. Ted is still visibly drunk, Chris is still shaking, and Randy's knuckles are even whiter. There's a box in the back where I died. It's full of all our belongings. My favorite shirt is peeking out the side. All red and ripe like a midsummer strawberry.

Randy rubs his baggy eyes as he turns on the country road. The pavement becomes gravel, and the wheels catch seizing up. The truck veers off the gravel. The front right wheel catches a ditch. The truck rides along like a monorail, bouncing so the gate pops down.

Randy fights the earth. Yanking the wheel left, the truck pops up and spits out dirt. There still isn't enough time, and they mow down a metal sign. When I open my eyes, there are lights.